



Free Work

Letting your dog sniff, explore and choose, while you quietly watch and learn

Most of the time we ask our dogs to do things: sit, wait, come, leave it. **Free Work** turns that around. You set up a small area with interesting surfaces, objects and a little food, then step back and let your dog explore it **in their own way, at their own pace**.

Free Work is part of **ACE (Animal Centred Education)**, developed by **Sarah Fisher** at Tilley Farm. ACE asks a different question: instead of "How do I make my dog do this?", we ask "Why does my dog do this?" Free Work is one of the ways we start to find out.

Why it helps

- **Choice.** Nothing is asked of your dog. For a nervous dog, simply being allowed to decide is powerful.
- **Sniffing and foraging.** Natural, calming behaviours that help the nervous system settle and let the stress bucket drain.
- **New experiences, gently.** Different textures, heights and objects build confidence without pressure.
- **Connection.** You become a calm, safe presence rather than someone giving instructions.

What it tells us

How a dog moves through a Free Work set-up can reveal a lot: which surfaces they avoid, how they lower their head to eat, whether they favour one side, whether they lie down or stay on the move.

These small details can point to **worry, tension or physical discomfort**, which often sits behind behaviour we find difficult. They help us decide where support is needed, sometimes from a vet or physiotherapist.

What you might notice

	Signs your dog is settling	Signs to slow down or simplify
Movement	Slower, looser movement; pausing to sniff; choosing to come back to things	Rushing round without stopping, or staying frozen at the edge
Body	Soft body, shaking off, stretching, lying down or rolling	Tense or crouched; tail tucked; avoiding certain surfaces or areas entirely
Eating	Taking food calmly from different heights and surfaces	Grabbing and gulping, guarding, or not wanting to eat at all
You	Checking in with you briefly, then going back to explore	Staying glued to you, or constantly looking to you for direction

Who it's good for

Free Work suits almost any dog: **nervous or reactive dogs**, **rescue dogs** settling into a new home, **puppies** meeting the world, **older dogs** who still love to explore, and dogs who find walks overwhelming. It's a gentle option on days when a walk isn't the right choice. If your dog is recovering from injury or on restricted exercise, check with your vet first.



Setting Up Free Work at Home

You probably already have everything you need

A SIMPLE SET-UP, FROM ABOVE



Rubber mat



Flattened cardboard



Egg box or muffin tin



Low, stable step



Folded towel



Water



Raised plate

● A few pieces of food, scattered across different surfaces and heights

What to use

- **3 to 6 different surfaces:** rubber or yoga mat, cardboard, a towel, a doormat.
- **Something at a different height:** a low, stable step or a sturdy box lid.
- **Food containers:** egg boxes, muffin tins, plates, a snuffle mat.
- **Fresh water** available throughout.
- A small amount of your dog's usual food or tasty treats.

During the session

- **Step back and stay quiet.** No cues, no luring, no pointing at the food.
- **Let your dog choose** what to explore, in what order, and what to ignore.
- **Keep it short:** 5 to 10 minutes is plenty to begin with.
- **Watch, don't judge.** Notice what your dog does and how they move.
- **Let them finish** when they wander off, lie down or shake off.

Afterwards

- Give your dog **quiet time to rest**. Many dogs settle or sleep afterwards.
- Jot down what you noticed: favourite surfaces, avoided areas, how they ate.
- **Change the set-up** next time, so it stays fresh and interesting.
- Share your notes and any videos with Flo, as they help us plan your dog's support.

⚠ Keep it safe

Always **supervise**. Make sure surfaces don't slip and steps can't tip. Avoid anything your dog might chew up and swallow. If your dog **guards food**, or you have more than one dog, run sessions **one dog at a time** and talk to Flo first.



Watch Sarah explain

See **Sarah Fisher** of Animal Centred Education share a top tip on video. There's no right or wrong way for your dog to do Free Work: whatever they choose is information. Scan the code, or visit [youtube.com/watch?v=IWmUiicTrSg](https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=IWmUiicTrSg)